

Screen

Screen size is important not just for viewing images, but also while zooming and focusing on the camera. The quality of the screen is important too. A 3-inch screen is standard, but anything between 2.5 to 3 inches will suffice. Colour depth of the screen is vital, so look for cameras that have LCD screens supporting 2,30,000 colours. A foldable screen will add bulk and weight to the camera, but they help protect the screen from stains and scratches when not in use. Make sure the hinge mechanism on such cameras is sturdy.



Batteries

Battery choice is personal. AA batteries are cheaper, and are easily available in local shops. So when you drain them, you can go out and buy a new set or at least carry an extra set or two with you. They are heavier than the widely used Lithium-ion batteries. Li-ion are the complete opposite — compact, light, but expensive. If you buy a Li-ion battery camera, try and find the cost of extra battery packs. The capacity of the batteries is also important.



AA batteries



Lithium Ion batteries

Aperture And Shutter Speed Priority Settings

Aperture priority settings allow you to set a fixed aperture size and all the other parameters change accordingly. Similarly, the shutter speed priority allows you to choose a shutter speed. This way, you can be sure that your images are not blurred in low light, or in long exposure shot. In short, these are advanced features that come very handy when you want to do more than just use the Auto mode to shoot photos.

Interface And Button Layout

The user interface should be easy to use. All the features and menus should be accessible with the least number of key-presses. The buttons should be also placed in such a manner that all the important functions can be accessed using a single hand. Look for cameras that have presets and scenery modes so you can simply set the camera to one of these modes and get to the shooting quickly.



Build Quality

While buying a camera, look for a well-built body. Make sure there are no loose battery or memory card doors that can possibly snap over time with rough use. Make sure the batteries don't shake and wobble around in the camera. If the camera has a lens cap, make sure it secures itself firmly to the camera. The quality of buttons on the camera is also important. The trigger and the zoom buttons should be sturdy, but not overly hard to press on. The half-press feel of the trigger for focusing should be distinguishable from the clicking. Any dials and mode selection knobs shouldn't be rigid.

Freebies Supplied

Prices of cameras might drop but don't stop looking for more. Manufacturers have begun bundling extras to go with the camera to try and make offers more attractive. Look for schemes that bundle a free camera pouch, a free charger with batteries and even memory cards. Some of the manufacturers might even offer free online web space for hosting images on their partner sites.



Camera pouch



Battery charger

Tripod Support

Low light shooting requires a stable base or the photos turn out blurred. Tripods come handy in such situations but cheap cameras might not always have a tripod mount. Check the bottom of the camera body to make sure the camera you buy has support for one.



Kind Of Memory Cards

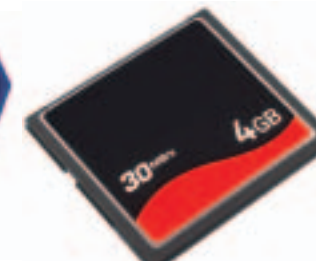
Cameras don't accept all kinds of memory cards. So consider prices of memory cards before you buy them. Certain kinds of memory such as SD are cheap, while proprietary ones are expensive.



Memory Stick



SD Card



Compact Flash

Say No To Digital Zoom!

Don't be impressed by large digital zoom numbers. Digital Zoom works by interpolation and there is massive loss to image quality. It's used mostly as a marketing gimmick. Practically, it's the same as zooming into an image in an image editor.

Flash

Cameras need to have powerful flashes. The flash found on P&S cameras are typically weak. Look for cameras that come with a synchronised or fill flash feature that can mellow down the intensity of the flash during your photo shoot. If possible, look for cameras that come with a mount for an external flash.



Manual Focus

All cameras today can automatically focus on objects with a simple press of a button. For the more creative sorts, one needs to experiment with different focus points. This is where Manual Focus is especially useful. You will not find this feature in lower-end cameras, is definitely something to opt for.